

Student Financial Assistance Scheme — Scheme Guidelines 2025

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These guidelines set out how the Student Financial Assistance Scheme operates. They explain the purpose, eligibility, benefits, application process, selection, disbursement and renewal arrangements so that students and institutions can use the scheme effectively.

1. Introduction

The Student Financial Assistance Scheme supports students facing financial barriers to enrolling in and completing higher education. It provides assistance with tuition, maintenance and, in specific cases, special needs so that financial circumstances do not determine educational opportunity. The scheme is administered by the Higher Education Department and delivered through the student welfare offices of participating institutions.

2. Objective

The scheme aims to: (i) reduce the share of students who discontinue study for financial reasons; (ii) enable talented students from lower-income households to pursue higher education; (iii) provide targeted support for students with disabilities and those from historically disadvantaged groups; and (iv) support tuition affordability in private and aided institutions.

3. Eligibility

- Enrolled in a recognised undergraduate or postgraduate programme in a participating institution.
- Family income within the ceiling notified for the academic year.
- Satisfactory academic progress as defined in Section 10.
- Not receiving equivalent financial support from another public source for the same purpose.
- For renewal: continued enrollment and compliance with progress requirements.

4. Benefit Components

The scheme provides the following assistance, subject to annual limits notified each year:

- Tuition assistance — paid directly to the institution against verified fees.
- Maintenance allowance — a fixed monthly amount paid to the student to support living costs.
- Special needs support — additional, verified assistance for students with disabilities, including assistive devices and reader or attendant costs.
- One-time support for unavoidable hardship — on application and documentation.

5. Application Period and Method

Applications are accepted during the notified window each academic year, typically at the start of the first semester. Students apply online through the HEIRS scholarship portal or, where online access is not available, through the institution's student welfare office, which assists with submission. Late applications are considered only where the student demonstrates exceptional circumstances.

6. Required Documents

- Proof of identity and proof of enrollment for the current academic year.
- Income evidence accepted by the scheme (income certificate or supported declaration).
- Academic records from the most recent examination.
- Bank account details for disbursement.
- Documentation of special needs, if applicable.
- Any other evidence requested during the district- or state-level verification.

7. Application Procedure

1. Check eligibility and the notified income ceiling before applying.
2. Complete the online application accurately and review before submission.
3. Attach the required documents in the specified formats.
4. Obtain the institution's verification before the closing date.
5. Track the application status through the portal and respond to any queries.
6. Keep the application ID and communication channel details for follow-up.

8. Selection and Disbursement

Applications are verified by the institution, then shortlisted by the department against the notified priorities — including household income, special needs, historically disadvantaged status and academic merit within income bands. Approved students are notified and benefits are disbursed directly: tuition to the institution and maintenance to the student's bank account. Disbursement is conditional on continued enrollment and verified fee liability.

9. Renewal

Support may be renewed for successive years of the programme. Renewal requires a fresh application, continued fulfillment of eligibility, and satisfactory academic progress. Students who fail to meet progress requirements may receive a warning, and continuous failure may lead to withdrawal of support after due process.

10. Academic Progress Requirement

- Pass a minimum share of credits/units each semester as notified by the institution.
- Maintain enrollment in the programme for which support was granted.
- Report any change in institution, programme or discontinuation immediately.
- Avail of counselling and academic support if progress is at risk, so that support can continue rather than lapse.

11. Roles and Responsibilities

Stakeholder	Key Responsibility
Higher Education Department	Set ceilings and priorities, approve, disburse and audit the scheme.
Institution (student welfare office)	Verify applications, certify enrollment and progress, and advise students.
Students	Apply accurately, submit documents, maintain progress and report changes.
Banks / disbursement partners	Transfer benefits safely and on time.

12. Monitoring and Redressal

The department monitors approval ratios, disbursement timelines and renewal rates, and publishes an annual utilisation summary. Grievances are handled first by the institution's student welfare office and escalated to the department's scholarship cell if unresolved. Redressal timelines are published on the scholarship portal.

13. Contact and Support Note

Students with questions should first contact their institution's student welfare office. The Scholarship Helpdesk and portal chat support provide assistance with the application process, status and document issues. This guide is illustrative only; notifications issued for each academic year prevail over any general description in this document.